

Startup Idea Validator

AI-Powered Skill for Claude (Cowork Mode & Claude Code)

Take any startup idea from a rough concept to a research-backed **GO / PIVOT / KILL** decision with evidence, not opinions. This skill handles AI-powered online research, generates customer interview scripts with scoring rubrics, and produces a final validation report.

Interview Mode	Research Mode	Scoring Mode
Build the problem/solution brief through guided questions	Multi-agent online analysis + human validation toolkit generation	Score interview data against rubrics, produce final GO/PIVOT/KILL verdict

How to Use This Skill

Claude Desktop (Cowork Mode): Open Cowork mode and drop your startup idea in. The skill triggers automatically.

Claude Code: Copy the startup-validator folder to your project's `.claude/skills/` directory, start a session, and describe your idea.

1. Interview Mode

The goal is to extract enough information to run a rigorous validation. Most founders underspecify their ideas. The skill asks the right questions in 4 rounds.

Round 1: The Basics

- Who specifically has this problem? (demographics, job title, income, geography)
- How do they solve this problem today? (current tools, workarounds, manual processes)

Round 2: Pain Depth

- How often does this problem occur? (daily, weekly, monthly)
- What does this problem cost them? (dollars, hours, missed opportunities)
- Have you talked to anyone who has this problem?

Round 3: The Solution

- What would your solution do specifically? (3-6 concrete capabilities)
- Why would someone switch from their current solution to yours?
- How would you charge for it? (subscription, per-use, freemium)

Round 4: Context & Constraints

- What's your budget and timeline?
- Do you know of any competitors?
- What would make you decide NOT to build this? (kill criteria)

After all rounds, the skill compiles a structured Problem/Solution Brief covering: the problem, target market, the solution, business model, known competitors, and kill criteria. The user confirms before moving to Research Mode.

2. Research Mode

Phase 1: Online Signal Mining

AI agents search Reddit, industry forums, YouTube, and app stores for pain evidence. 8+ search queries adapted to the specific industry. Records source, quotes, engagement, URLs.

- Total posts/reviews found about the pain
- Top 3 pain points ranked by frequency
- AI/tech sentiment breakdown (positive/negative/unaware)
- Confidence score (1-10) that the pain exists
- 5 YouTube channels identified as potential interview candidates
- 5 worst app store complaints about existing tools

Phase 2: Competitive Intelligence

Maps every competitor with pricing, features, funding, sentiment, and threat level. Validates market size (TAM/SAM/SOM) from 2+ independent sources. Delivers feature comparison matrix and pricing landscape table.

Phase 3: Strategic Solutions (4 Parallel Agents)

Agent	Delivers
A: Pricing Strategy	Exact tier names/prices, free trial structure, revenue projections at 300/1K/5K customers, LTV & CAC estimates
B: Differentiation	#1 wedge feature, positioning statement, 3 unique claims, moat strategy
C: Trust & Adoption	90-day trust timeline, messaging guide, community strategy, referral program design
D: Go-to-Market	Channel rankings with CAC, specific communities/podcasts/conferences, ad budget scenarios

Phase 4: Compile Online Research Deliverables

Produces a Validation Tracker (.xlsx) with sheets: Dashboard, Online Signals, Competitor Intel, App Reviews, YouTube Research, Strategy Solutions, Sources.

3. Human Validation Toolkit

The critical bridge between AI research and real-world validation. Produces THREE deliverables for the founder:

5A. Customer Interview Script (.docx)

A printable, customized interview guide with 6 sections:

Section	Duration	What It Covers
1. Opening & Rapport	2-3 min	Warm-up questions, day-to-day role discussion
2. Pain Discovery	10-15 min	Open-ended pain questions, follow-up probes from online research
3. Solution Reaction	5-8 min	Demo/description, first reaction, inline 1-5 scoring rubric
4. Willingness to Pay	3-5 min	Van Westendorp 4-question method + specific price test
5. Commitment & Close	3-5 min	Trial interest, referrals, commitment level (1-5)
6. AI/Tech Sentiment	2-3 min	AI attitude, past tool experience, trust factors

5B. Interview Kit Spreadsheet (.xlsx)

A standalone spreadsheet the founder fills in during/after each interview. 4 sheets:

Sheet 1: Interview Log - 22 columns with dropdowns and conditional formatting

Columns	What's Tracked
A-D	#, Name/ID, Date, Source (dropdown)
E-G	Years in Role, Hours/Week on Pain, Top #1 Pain
H-J	Pain Score (1-5), Demo Score (1-5), WTP Score (1-5) - color coded
K-M	AI Sentiment (dropdown), Preference (dropdown), Top Concern
N-Q	Van Westendorp: Too Cheap, Great Deal, Expensive, Too Expensive (\$)
R-V	Commit Level (1-5), Would Pay \$X+?, Core Pain Top-3?, Open to Solution?, Money Quote

Sheet 2: Live Dashboard - Auto-updating kill/pivot/go verdict

Reads from Interview Log with COUNTIF, AVERAGE, MEDIAN formulas. Shows kill criteria (red), go criteria (green), Van Westendorp pricing section, and a final verdict cell that auto-calculates GO/PIVOT/KILL.

Sheet 3: Scoring Rubrics - Reference sheet for during interviews

Clean rubric tables: Pain Score, Demo Score, WTP Score, Commit Level, AI Sentiment. Each score (1-5) with description and example quote.

Sheet 4: Outreach Tracker - Pre-populated with research targets

Tracks name, platform, date contacted, response status, interview scheduled. Pre-filled with Reddit users, YouTubers, and forum users found during online research.

4. Scoring Rubrics

Pain Score (1-5)

Score	Description	Example Quote
1	Doesn't have this problem	"I don't really deal with that"
2	Minor annoyance, not worth solving	"Yeah it's annoying but I deal with it"
3	Noticeable, would consider solutions	"I've looked into fixing this"
4	Significant, actively looking	"I've been searching for something better"
5	Critical, desperate	"This costs me real money every week"

Demo Score (1-5)

Score	Description
1	Not interested, doesn't see the value
2	Mild interest, many objections
3	Sees the value, wouldn't switch yet
4	Excited, would try it, some concerns
5	Wants to sign up immediately

Willingness to Pay Score (1-5)

Score	Description
1	Would only use if free
2	Would pay <\$20/month
3	Would pay \$20-50/month
4	Would pay \$50-100/month
5	Would pay \$100+/month

Commitment Level (1-5)

Level	Signal	Strength
1	"Sounds interesting"	Polite - not a real signal
2	"I'd try the free version"	Low commitment

3	"I'd pay for that"	Strong verbal signal
4	"How do I sign up? Early access?"	Very strong
5	"Take my money / let me share with friends"	Unicorn

5. Kill / Pivot / Go Logic

KILL Criteria (any one = kill)

- Core pain in top-3 for target users: KILL if <3 of 15 interviews
- Would try the solution: KILL if <4 of 15
- Would pay target price/mo: KILL if <1 of 15

PIVOT Criteria (investigate further)

- Average pain score 2.5-3.4 - pain exists but not severe enough
- Average WTP 2.0-2.9 - they want it but won't pay enough
- Preferred model contradicts plan - delivery model needs rethinking
- Online research said X but interviews said Y - real-world differs from online signal

GO Criteria (all must pass)

- Pain score average $\geq 3.5/5$
- Demo score average $\geq 3.5/5$
- WTP score average $\geq 3.0/5$
- Would use + would pay: ≥ 8 use & ≥ 5 pay of 15
- Commit Level 4+ ≥ 3 people
- Van Westendorp supports pricing
- No kill criteria triggered

GO

Data says build it

PIVOT

Adjust & revalidate

KILL

Save your 6 months

6. Scoring Mode

When the founder returns with completed interview data, the skill:

- **Step 1: Ingest Data** - Reads the filled Interview Kit spreadsheet or accepts verbal results
- **Step 2: Calculate Rubric Scores** - Pain validation, solution validation, willingness to pay, commitment quality
- **Step 3: Apply Kill/Pivot/Go Logic** - Scores each criterion as PASS / FAIL / BORDERLINE
- **Step 4: Pattern Analysis** - Top quotes, feature request clustering, objection mapping, segment discovery, online vs. interview alignment
- **Step 5: Final Validation Report (.docx)** - 12-section comprehensive report combining online + human research
- **Step 6: Update Tracker** - Dashboard scored with traffic lights, final verdict cell calculated
- **Step 7: Present Verdict** - Concise summary with confidence %, next steps for THIS WEEK

Final Report Structure (12 Sections)

1. Executive Summary (1 page) - idea, verdict, 3 key findings
2. Pain Validation (2-3 pages) - online + interview evidence
3. Solution Validation (2-3 pages) - demo reactions, feature requests
4. Pricing Validation (2 pages) - Van Westendorp analysis
5. Competitive Landscape (2 pages) - updated matrix
6. Customer Profile (1-2 pages) - best customer persona
7. Rubric Scorecard (1 page) - full PASS/FAIL table with grade A-F
8. Strategic Recommendations (2-3 pages) - updated pricing, positioning, GTM
9. If GO: 90-Day Build Plan (2 pages)
10. If PIVOT: Pivot Options (2 pages)
11. If KILL: Lessons Learned (1 page)
12. Appendix - all sources, interview data, Van Westendorp curves

7. Validation Checklist

Phase 1: Online Signal Mining [AI does this]

- Search 10+ Reddit threads for pain evidence
- Search 3+ industry forums
- Analyze 20+ app store reviews of competitors
- Identify 5+ YouTube channels in the space
- Map 5+ direct competitors with pricing
- Validate market size from 2+ sources
- Compile evidence summary with confidence score

Phase 2: Outreach & Recruitment [Founder does this]

- Post in 3+ relevant communities asking for interviews
- Send 20+ DMs to target users
- Reach out to 3+ YouTubers/influencers
- Set up scheduling link (Calendly/similar)
- Target: 15+ confirmed interview slots

Phase 3: Discovery Interviews [Founder does this]

- Complete interviews #1-5, review for early kill signals
- Complete interviews #6-10, check Dashboard
- Complete interviews #11-15
- All 15+ interviews recorded and scored

Phase 4: Demo Reactions [Founder does this]

- Create 2-minute product demo
- Show demo to all 15 interviewees
- Record demo scores + top 3 feature requests + top 3 objections

Phase 5: Pricing Validation [Founder does this]

- Run Van Westendorp on all 15 interviewees
- Record all 4 price points per person
- Compare median 'Great Deal' to proposed pricing

Phase 6: Landing Page Smoke Test [Founder does this]

- Build landing page with value proposition

- Drive 200+ visitors from 2+ channels
- Measure conversion rate (target: 5%+ for waitlist)

Phase 7: Final Synthesis [Bring data back to skill]

- All interview data entered in tracker
- Run Scoring Mode for final verdict
- GO / PIVOT / KILL decision made with evidence

8. Key Principles

Evidence over opinions. Every claim must cite a source. '280 forum posts discuss this pain, 12/15 interviewees confirmed it, average pain score 4.2/5' is valuable.

Parallel execution. Run research agents simultaneously. The founder's time is the bottleneck, not compute.

Specific numbers. Never say 'consider a freemium model.' Say '\$29/month base, targeting 1,000 users at \$1.35M ARR.'

Honest kill signals. If the data says kill, say kill. A fast 'don't build this' is more valuable than a slow failure.

The rubric is law. Don't override kill/pivot/go criteria with vibes. Present data honestly and let the founder decide.

Interviews beat internet. Online research is a starting signal. Interview data always wins when there's a conflict. 15 real conversations > 1,000 Reddit posts.

Adapt to the industry. Search queries, communities, interview questions, and pricing methods change completely between industries.

Closed-ended scoring + open-ended quotes. The rubric gives you numbers to compute verdicts. The quotes give you insight the numbers miss. Always capture both.